

Unjust Religion as Fiction

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Abstract

In medieval bestiaries, there are two classes of evil represented by beasts; those which deceive and those which generate fear and death. Among the first class of beasts, those which are notable for their abilities to deceive, there are three kinds of deception: these are noted by the camouflages of the chameleon, accurate imitations of the manticore, and the “seductive skills of sirens”.

- **Deceivers:** Camouflage, imitation, seduction
 - Chameleon: camouflage
 - Manticore: accurate imitations
 - Sirens: seductive skills
- **Fear and Death Generators**

While we might think this to be a medieval taxonomy of epistemic harms only, the kinds of epistemic harms the medievalists worried about are not far off from contemporary epistemic harms and risks; misinformation, false and inauthentic narratives, and bullsh*t. This article looks at those beasts which represent epistemic harms and attempts to develop an account of inauthentic narrative as a moral harm.

Pinero: Beasts as Symbols of Evil

The Manticore is a fictionalized beast that was born in Persian art and literature sometime around Persia’s cultural zenith. It at once symbolizes evil, death and hell, but in medieval religious art, it came to symbolize the power of Christ over death and hell.

It is an imagined beast that has been found in literature as early as the 5th and 4th century BC. In his Photius, the Greek historian working for the Persian court describes the Manticore as a beast with red skin, as large as a lion, possessing three rows of teeth, a human-like face and the tail of a scorpion. Later writers would quote Ctesias’ description of the Manticore adding emphasis on its dietary habits, including that it ate men. Though it is likely that many of these descriptions were of predatory animals passed by word of mouth until they reached the Persian king’s court, what is even more important is the way in which these descriptions begin to stand in for imageries of evil in the Medieval literature and specifically the kinds of evil they begin to represent.

On some accounts, the manticore is a union between a hyena and Ethiopian lioness. It imitates the voices of men and possesses a fixed and immovable gaze. In addition, it does not possess gums in either of its jaws, and rather than having multiple teeth, it has one large one that curves around its jaw bone.

Ctesias’ description includes that the Manticore had a triple row of teeth which fit in its face and ears of a human, blood colored eyes, the body of a lion and a stinging tail s



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Pliny the elder argued that it imitated the voices of men, Ctesias tells us that its voice resembles a union of a flute and trumpet, that it is exceedingly swift, and has an appetite for human flesh [p. 280].

Aristotle questions Ctesias' account, but nevertheless preserves it in his own writings. He also reproduces Ctesias' account, that the Manticore possesses a double rather than triple row of teeth, has similar feet as a lion and is similar in size to a lion. What is perhaps important are the anthropomorphic descriptions including those of the ears and face of a human, and that it has non-anthropomorphic ones such as grey eyes and red body and possesses a tail like that of a scorpion. [p. 30-31; also see Aristotle, History of Animals 8.28, 605b22-606a10]

Owing to the fantastical nature of these accounts, it is highly probable that they are either misguided representations of some more familiar animal, or motivated by purposes other than truth. In the classical era, it is most likely the case that the Manticore is a confused representation of some other more familiar animal, while in the medieval period, the motivation for the representation lies outside of truth.

On this second point, in the 57th question of the 1st of the second part of the Summa Theologica, Thomas Aquinas defends the view of art as a form of right reason. There is a distinction here between the right reason for making objects, and the right reason for doing good actions. We should first focus on a central point here, what is important to both of these activities, namely the right use of one's cognitive faculties. Therefore, the difference here lies in the aesthetic representation, whether of an action or object.

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If we are to ask ourselves what justifies our emotional responses to some given experience, on the one hand we might consider that the validity of the experience rests in something like the authenticity of the experience. Assuming that artistic experiences are driven by the same norms as other experiences, the image of the Manticore would generate fear in those who were lucky enough to witness an artistic representation of one, whether literary or visual. However, artistic experiences are not always governed by the same norms as other kinds of experiences. Some additional norms that govern our experiences with fiction include pleasure, entertainment, and absorption (Gilmore 2020, 132). However, this would mark an important divergence from the functions of art accepted by the medievalist, and those accepted by us today.

Art as an Orthodox End

We might think that medieval art has no place in a discussion about epistemic injustice, but I argue that the depiction of the fictional beast called the manticore, as a personification of deception lends credibility to this claim. According to the modern function of art summed up by Gilmore (2020), art's function is oriented to ends such as pleasure, entertainment, and absorption [132]. Conversely, the medieval function of art is directed at more orthodox ends intending to motivate desirable behaviors and behavioral responses. According to views centering on epistemic injustice, because of a misappropriated power imbalance, a person holds false beliefs about themselves. These beliefs stem from unjust environments where the individual lacks access to resources that

would lead to accurate self-understanding and moral beliefs. Such beliefs are rooted in irrational actions performed by that individual.

It does this by contrasting the concept of hermeneutic justice as popularized by Miranda Fricker (2007) but developed by earlier feminists. We might think that medieval art has no place in a discussion about epistemic injustice, but I argue that the depiction of the fictional beast called the manticore, as a personification of deception lends credibility to this claim. According to the modern function of art, art's function is oriented to ends such as pleasure, entertainment, and absorption (Gilmore 2020, 132). Conversely, the medieval function of art is directed at more orthodox ends, ones intending to motivate behaviors and behavioral responses. As an artistic object, the Manticore is a fictionalized beast that was born in Persian art and literature sometime around its cultural zenith. It at once symbolizes evil, death and hell, but in medieval religious art, it came to symbolize the power of Christ over death and hell.

Currie's Fiction

Why do we think that fairy tales are fiction but news stories are not? Is fake news the same thing as a fairy tale? During the pandemic, fake news became a widely discussed talking point. A less widely discussed talking point however was why don't we just call it fiction? A derivative of this question is how fiction is made possible. Meaning, what are the creative differences between fake news, news news and fairy tales? To answer this question, Gregory Currie (1990) suggests three possible answers.

According to the front page news, the terrorist leader Amelia Boyd was killed by the Headhunters Gang. First are the characteristics that distinguish fiction from non-fiction. This question is a close investigation of the entities that are in fiction and make them possible. For instance, the psychological and linguistic resources that producers and consumers of fiction must have access to.

First, consider that fiction uses language. But there is no universal linguistic feature shared by all fictional works and there is no available proof/s confirming what is a fiction. We usually think that reading a work is an act of reading words and sentences that make it up.² However, consider a mime? Or silent films? These are works that do not use language in the traditional sense, yet we consider them fictional. Therefore, what makes something a fiction cannot necessarily be a linguistic feature. Therefore what makes something a fiction is neither a necessary nor sufficient condition for being fictional. Finally then, something can be a fiction because of its verbal structure, but what makes it a fiction does not lie in the text itself.

Semantic Properties

Currie concludes that fictionality is a relational property, it is something possessed in virtue of the text's relations to other things. Therefore while it is possible that fictionality is a linguistic matter, what makes it a fiction lies in some other property. (a method of communication or other communicative practice)

On this account, fictional properties, like non-fictional ones, have the semantic properties of truth value and reference. What this means is that a fictional statement can be true and false. For instance, consider the statement "Killing an NPC in monitored space will earn you a crime state". According to Currie, this statement is true. What makes something true or false in a fiction, is its relation to the outside world and so what is important then, is what this relationship is.

Because fiction is a relational property, they are community based and “depend on the prevailing attitudes of the community, or of a subgroup of the community rather than the ideas of a single individual” (Currie 1990, 10).

For I take it that an act of joint authorship is exactly that: an act engaged in by more than one person rather than several distinct acts undertaken individually and patched together. (Currie 1990, 11)

The process of creating a fiction begins with the intention. It is not a singular intention however, but is a social enterprise. So maybe the reason that we do not call fake news, fiction, is because of the purposes and intent of fake news. It is intended to deceive rather than express true propositions. But if this is true, then why do we not consider that fiction is intended to deceive? Why does fiction have semantic properties such as truth whereas fake news does not? Currie (1990)

Pinero

Piñero Moral (2021) argues that this is because art’s purpose in the middle ages is to represent reality. It is one thing to accurately and factually represent a tree, however, Pinero is talking about more complex reality, especially moral reality. One example of medieval representations of moral reality include the Persian Manticore. The manticore as depicted in medieval art is said to represent evil.

There are several ways in which some art objects may represent more complex realities. One may think that the purpose of a painting is to reflect the experiences one had during a war, or peace time event. Such a painting may express the given facts of the case, for instance an artist could paint the signing of the Magna Carta. If the painting were painted by an artist who was alive to witness the signing of the Magna Carta, then the artist would merely be representing contemporary reality. If the artist were not alive at the time, then we could argue that the artist is representing historical reality. The artist is relying on trusted and well known sources would be different from the artist imagining an event in which not many direct sources exist. But an artist can represent a projection of reality as well when the reality they want to convey is obscure, not well known, highly contested or hypothetical.

According to this definition of medieval art, art implies metaphysical aspirations and normative elements (Also see De Bruyne 1959). Its commitment to reality is undeniable, yet the reality which it attempts to represent is so complex and vast that the limits between what is and what is not, between what we believe and what we know, between what we are and what we wish to be, are often blurred (cron41?).

Here, the artist can represent facts as they believe them to be, or as they wish them to be. It is this latter motivation that Pinero suggests motivated medieval artwork representing the manticore. There is a difference here then between modern and medieval artistic function. This in itself is uninteresting. However, what may be more interesting to the reader, is the further claim that this difference can be applied in response to the contemporary account of epistemic injustice.

Considering a product that is produced, the desired outcome of the activity of art, it is not clear what it is exactly, that we care about in the case of art. When it comes to what is produced in the case of art, it is not clear whether the final thing produced is an action, or a material commodity. The common contemporary understanding considers various perspectives. However, it is important to understand two important points here.

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The difference lies in the produced object, whether an action or thing. But here, we should pause momentarily or we risk conflating two senses of right action. In the ancient context, right action would more probably be used to reference actions that align with a dominant organizational structure, for instance the Catholic church. In our own

modern context, we are less apt to recognize a singular dominant moral authority. This presents a problem since we would want to say something more akin to ‘beneficial’, or ‘productive’ action where ‘benefit’ and ‘product’ are more expressive of individual tastes and desires.

Considering a product that is produced, the desired outcome of the activity of art, it is not clear what it is exactly, that we collectively care about in the case of art then. When it comes to what is produced by artistic endeavor, it is not clear whether a normative account should include a material commodity, or a desired outcome apart from a material commodity. When we think about what a good artistic endeavor entails, in the modern conception, there is typically some monetary component. For instance, an admirable artistic endeavor at the center of an advertising campaign would ideally result in increased revenue for the advertising clients and increased business for the advertiser.

However, the medieval conception of an admirable artistic endeavor consists of outcomes which invoke some kind of behavior. Whether dispositions or actions, ultimately there is a desire for an intended outcome as it correlates specifically with a human actor. Harrison (2011) argues for instance, that Elizabeth Gaskell’s novel *Mary Barton: A Tale of Manchester Life* was in part responsible for the UK’s expanded social safety net. Gaskell represented the suffering and distress experienced by the working poor in a way that allowed her upper-class Victorian audience to empathize with the lower social classes (Harrison 2011, 258). For instance, we might think that a good artist produces items of great monetary value. But using the medieval depiction as expressed above, it seems that a good artist instead motivates an actor to behave in a way that produces good outcomes. The common contemporary understanding considers various perspectives. However, it is important to understand the two important points here.

It is this distinctive kind of epistemic harm/injustice that consists of undermining our ability to convey knowledge to others and make sense of our own experiences (Fricker 2007).

Susan Pepper-Gates in a forth-coming paper writes a very engaging and important paper article applying Miranda Fricker (2007)’s analysis of epistemic injustice to contemporary Western Religion WR, and the Philosophy of Religion, PoWR. She argues that the philosophy of religion should cultivate epistemic-ethical virtues in order to recognize and include philosophers from minority voices. Doing so helps WR and PoWR understand and recognize the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

I think that the initial conclusion is a strong one. Namely the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings is important for concepts that we associate with who we are. However, I think that the most important conclusion here is a premise conclusion statement. Rather than WR and PoWR cultivating epistemic virtues, WR and PoWR should focus on the cultivation of epistemic virtues, meaning that they should focus on how epistemic virtue is created. This will give the project of WR and PoWR two convergent aims.

1. First, it would be to draw attention to the ways in which power **can** shape our lives as embodied social beings.
2. Cultivating virtue in this context then, means that WR and PoWR ought be formative, cultivating virtue in their audiences.
3. However, possessing virtue in this sense, makes it less likely that power will shape the lives of WR and PoWR’s audiences.

Some Questions

A central question here is one of difference in kinds of harm. Specifically what kind of harm is being done. Additionally, is the kind of harm that we care about adjudicated solely in virtue of racial, or ethnic distinctiveness?

Peppers-Gates Analysis of Fricker

Peppers-Gates first points out that Western Religion, WR, and The Philosophy of Western Religion, PoWR, have historically ignored work by intersectional feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge the traditional approach. However, how is this done? First, traditional epistemology, TE, focuses on abstract universal knowledge while the philosophy of religion has traditionally grounded itself in TE by focusing on rational belief.

In order for the philosophy of religion to cultivate epistemic-ethical virtues, it should recognize and include philosophers from minority voices. Peppers-Gates argument takes the following form:

1. Traditional epistemology focuses on abstract universal knowledge.
2. Philosophy of religion grounds itself in traditional epistemology and focuses on rational belief.
3. Therefore WR and PoWR embrace narrow methodologies that exclude others and contributes to the marginalization of minority voices.
4. Given its focus on abstract universal knowledge and its marginalization of minority voices, WR and PoWR ignore work by intersectional feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge the traditional approach and argue that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.
5. As such, WR and PoWR conflate the truth about the existence and attributes of a [pateriachal] God with traditional epistemic approaches grounded in [narrow methological approaches to knowledge].
6. By focusing on narrow methodologies and abstract conceptions of knowledge, WR and PoWR fail to consider ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

A central point in the above argument is that WR and PoWR have silenced marginalized groups. These include women, people of color, disabled persons and members of the LGBTQI+ community. As stated above, the reason for this is because traditional epistemology focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge and thereby fails to consider the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings. We might think however, that the argument rests on a notion of rules bias. Namely that by using certain conversational rules in philosophical discourse, that PoWR and WR silence minority groups due to their falling in some way to abide by these rules of discourse.

To see how this is the case, we can use the grammar contrast. Here, we assume that a person can learn grammar and we exclude them from the larger conversation until they do. But this would be an unfair response to the above argument. On the one hand, we could argue that it is grounded in a misreading of the argument, that minority voices are excluded from the philosophical lexicon not because they have failed to abide by the rules of philosophical discourse, but because either 1) their topics of concern fall outside the margin of interest, or 2) because of some varying identifying physical characteristic, such as failure to develop a 'rational' argument as determined by the implied narrow rules of discourse. But this would be a misrepresentation of the above argument.

The way I understand Peppers-Gates argument, is that marginalized groups have been excluded from philosophical discourse because of certain hermeneutic challenges, namely the way they are *understood* as

having failed to abide by the rules of philosophical discourse. Therefore, we can amend the above argument in the following way:

1. TE focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge.
2. PoWR grounds itself in TE by focusing on ‘rational’ belief in its debates about God’s existence and attributes.
3. Therefore PoWR ignores feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge PoWR’s rules which are grounded in TE.
4. As such, WR and PoWR have silenced marginal groups.
5. PoWR’s embrace of its narrow methodology and range of topics then is based in an exclusion of ‘others’ from meaning making in institutional philosophy.

The final premise then says that the narrow methodology employed by PoWR is not a natural methodology, but is rather exclusive in its construction. Meaning that it is narrow specifically for the purposes of excluding minority views and opinions within the lexicon. As such, I understand that the paper defends the following conclusion:

The Philosophy of Western Religion focuses on rational belief and conflates this with evolving and misapplied lexical rules in its debates about the existence and attributes of a patriarchal God.

Silencing

Western religion and the philosophy of religion have silenced marginalized groups by focusing on abstract conceptions of knowledge which fail to consider ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings. This is because traditional epistemology focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge. These abstract conceptions of knowledge are inadequate because they do not analyze the ways power shapes our lives as “embodied social beings”. We are born in webs of meaning and social relations of power and privilege. Some voices are heard, meaning they pass review, and therefore shape the social imagination. Others are ignored however. These others then are incapable of shaping the social imagination.

On the one hand, a defense of the traditional power structure would make sure to emphasize what it means to participate in the sort of debate that does have the potential to shape the social imagination. How is one’s voice heard? One way is through the enforcement of so-called grammar rules. Taking an art class, the professor attempts to communicate the rules which apply to a given art genre. However, the students note the many deviations from these rules, the supposed exceptions. The professor then replies by saying that “once you know how to apply the rules, then you are allowed to break the rules”. An imagined analogy would be a reviewer rejecting a paper for the alleged abuse of grammar rules that a more seasoned author would be allowed to bend. A concern here is one where the so-called rules are being inappropriately applied as a means of gate-keeping who gets to shape the ‘social-imagination’. A student who fails to learn the rules, is not accepted into the art community, where work is posted in galleries, sold at auctions, is not publicly (positively or negatively) reviewed etc,. Of additional importance here, is that assuming a more seasoned author is justified in bending the lexical rules of philosophical discourse, than the more seasoned author can also be seen as contributing to the development of the lexicon rules surrounding philosophical discourse. As such, the more seasoned professional is allowed to shape the rules of discourse, and thereby contribute to the social imagination.

As such, the harm which ought to concern us here includes the exclusion of individuals from the generally shared social understanding. Excluding voices in this way contributes to their harm or can be used as a weapon to harm individual. But what is this weapon and how specifically does it as a weapon cause harm? In the following section, I will show how participation in the shared lexical structure has been called a marker of humanity. Therefore gatekeepers undermine the process by which a person becomes human.

Hermeneutic Injustice

1. When DSS (Dominant Social Structure) of meaning exclude you or distort your experiences, and no social concepts that you recognize capture your vision of yourself, then your capacity as a knower and your own self-understanding have been stunted.
 1. But this introduces a very narrow vision of social structure. Isn't it possible that while you are excluded from a dss, a non-dss, one that includes you and does not distort your experiences, could still capture a vision of yourself, and your capacity as a knower and fortifying your self-understanding.
 2. What is needed then is a new non-dss, education.
 3. While a person is excluded from a dss, they could have their capacity as a knower fortified by a non-dss, education reimagined.

The need to reimagine education.

1. WR and PoR become DSS's of meaning and exclude some or distort their experiences
2. But this introduces a very narrow vision of social structure.
 1. It is possible that while you are excluded from a dss, a non-dss, one that includes you and does not distort your experiences, could still capture a vision of yourself, and your capacity as a knower and fortifying your self-understanding.
 2. So while a person is excluded from a dss, they could have their capacity as a knower fortified by a non-dss.
3. Therefore 2 this does not mean that there are no social concepts that you recognize and capture your vision of yourself and your capacity as a knower and your own self-understanding are stunted but not by the DSS, but the lack of the non-dss.

One Possible example of hermeneutic injustice against religious minorities

Secular community marginalization against people of religious faith.

1. PoRF may lack 'sensibilities and resources needed to make sense of religious people's experiences,' (Kidd, 20217).
2. But does not capture gravity of systemic cases of hermeneutical injustice whose targets experience multiple forms of injustice.
 1. Hermeneutical marginalization "entails marginalization of a socioeconomic sort', targets will not 'participate on equal terms within the practices of law, academia, politics, religion, journalism, media, etc. (Fricker, 2010).
 2. However, DSS vs. non-DSS? While DSS of meaning may distort experiences, non-dss may not, instead rejecting dss of meaning which says that "there are no social concepts which capture a religious person's

vision of themselves (i.e., made in image of God, human dignity bestowed by God, not DSS, etc.)”.

Consider the following claims:

3. Here, Fricker, a published philosopher, the DSS, says persons of a certain sort are marginalized and therefore have been silenced. But here, marginalization means they lack a marker of humanity. As such, Fricker claims that certain individuals lack a marker of humanity.
4. Why? For not adhering to rules of rationality practiced by the dss. Surely they could however do so?
5. Because of 1, they lack participation in shared meaning.
6. Therefore lack capacity as knowers.
7. From 3, their self-understanding is mitigated and stunted.
8. Participation in shared hermeneutic, i.e., 1-4, in shared conceptual structure is a marker of humanity”.
9. Therefore, because of exclusion from shared conceptual structure, they lack a marker of humanity.

but rather than ‘victims’ being excluded from shared conceptual structure and lacking capacity as knowers and lacking marker of humanity, they instead are included in different conceptual structure (e.g., religious conceptual structure) which fortifies their capacity as knowers and self-understanding, acting as marker of humanity.

On Greek Tragedy

Three Kinds of Tragic Conflict

1. Good people being ruined because of things that just happen to them, things they do not control.
2. Good people doing bad things, things opposite of their ethical character and commitments because of things they do not control.
3. Good people doing bad things without direct physical compulsion and opposite of their ethical character and commitments though done in light of circumstances of equally bad choices.

Agammenon is waiting on the shore with his entire fleet. He intends to carry out a directive from Zeus to avenge his brother whose wife ran away with Paris, prince of Troy. However, because of an earlier transgression against Artemis, Artemis is holding back the wind, stranding his fleet. Agammenon, as the result of an omen of an eagle devouring a hare, is told that in order to appease Artemis, he must sacrifice his daughter Iphigenia.

As such, Agammenon is faced with two impossible choices, fail to carry out Zeus’s command, or kill his daughter. It is important to point out that the fleet is already facing starvation being stranded on the coast. However, Agammenon’s sin, is not that he chooses sacrificing his daughter, instead it is the way he sacrificed his daughter.

- Like in the biblical story of Abraham, a good man must kill an innocent child “out of obedience to a divine command” [35].
- Agammenon’s sin however, is not the choice, but rather how the choice was made:
 - Agammenon now begins to cooperate inwardly with necessity, arranging his feelings to accord with his fortune.
 - From the moment he makes his decision, itself the best he could have made, he strangely turns himself into a collaborator, a willing victim [35].

Progression of loss of agency:

- Necessity of the act
- to the rightness of the act
- to the rightness of the feelings of the act

In another paper, I highlighted some concerns raised by Wendy Laybourn (2018) regarding representation and authenticity. Here, I want to draw attention to some additional similar concerns. What is important here, is that these criticisms unfairly focus too narrowly on the black experience and do not do a good enough job in recognizing that these experiences are universal. Given their universality, I argue that a best response is found in a Christian theodicy to evil. I draw on the psychological literature of in-group and out-group behavior.

Laybourn (2018)'s criticism of black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness is a commodified identity that is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls controlling images in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations and not in themselves harmful. Yet too, this is also a common trope.

I present this case as an example of a paradigmatic concept of hermeneutic injustice. It is not clear just what aspects of the member's lives are represented, nor specifically which images are harmful if such images are accepted as representative. An important question here has to do with the relationship between popular narratives that contain these images, and personal identity. One approach argues that we are defined by the stories we accept about ourselves, but this is controversial.

Wendy Laybourn's Cost of Being Real

Research on black authenticity identifies "oppressive othering" and "white standards of beauty", particularly lighter skin tone, as key components of commercial success in the entertainment industry.

- Oppressive Othering (commodified black authenticity, cba)
- White Standards of Beauty (wsb)

In this note, I am only going to focus on oppressive othering / commodified black authenticity, cba.

Are rap lyrics a case of oppressive othering? By using rap lyrics, Laybourn argues that we can compare oppressive othering with white standards of beauty. However, the way she does so is by drawing attention to a positive correlation between lighter skin tone and higher Billboard chart ratings.

There wasn't a similar relation noticed between rap lyrics (oppressive othering) and higher chart ratings though at the center of this issue seems to be a suggestion that a harmful representation of blackness is sold to the public as "authentic blackness". Importantly, this particular commodity then "shapes" what is accepted as authentic blackness, and what is commodified as authentic blackness.

In addition to the "oppressive othering" of cba, "white standards" of beauty are also sold. But it isn't clear what correlation there is between cba and wsb if any. Laybourn argues that both wsb and cba stem from attitudes which position blacks as an outgroup and whites as an in-group.

As such, when cbas are dangerous when they serve as an avenue for interaction with black culture and a proxy for interpersonal interaction with black Americans, even though they are created within a framework "that" reifies

anti-blackness. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and of the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful. Therefore, there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are harmful ([20C History Project 2014](#); [Collins 2006, 2009](#); [Sartwell 1998](#)).

Laybourn more narrowly defines cba as one dominant group's creation of more inferior groups. This is accomplished through media portrayals linking anti-social behaviors, violence, abuse, crime, to these other groups.

Patricia Collins Black Feminist Thought

In the 2009 version of Collin's Black Feminist Thought, BFT, Collins draws greater emphasis between relationships of knowledge and power. It is often said

- that knowledge = power,

but a worrying theme throughout the book, is that this is wrong and that rather

- power = knowledge.

One might notice the misapplication of a logical principle here, because whenever we use the equals sign, there is not a logical difference between power = knowledge and knowledge = power.

Rather, this says that power is identical in value to knowledge and if power is identical to knowledge, then knowledge is identical to power.

In other words, the initial application claims that the direction of fit is not directional but rather than uni- or bi-directional.

For instance, we could look at some possible relationships between knowledge and power below:

- knowledge $\rightarrow$ power

or

- power $\rightarrow$ knowledge

or

- knowledge $\leftrightarrow$ power

Initially, we might think that assuming that if one has knowledge then the correct state of affairs should be that they will fulfill their aims, whatever those may be. This is often a selling point for higher education.

This is a common position in what is lauded as "African American Studies". Often times these positions are wrapped in the language of "struggle". While Collins notes that this "struggle" is a struggle for empowerment, it is not particularly clear who the struggle is directed at. She argues that the struggle is global and transcendent, and

she defines it as one for “survival.” But she expands the target in the most recent edition of her book to include recent developments in the areas of sexuality and “sexual politics” of black womanhood.

Some similar examples of this criticism can be found in Zakiyyah Iman Jackson (2020) or Mbembe (2017)’s Critique of Black Reason. Jackson (2020) defends the view of race as a social construct. Here black represents a void of reason and a surplus of animality. It is not clear what the counter to this claim should be as it is not represented anywhere in either work. However, looking at what is deemed black culture broadly in popular media, this counter claim is even more difficult to understand given that many African Americans fail to explicitly and publicly criticize, or at the very least, argue that such behaviors are not culturally representative.

Popular artists who reflect similar characteristics as those deemed synonymous to the black race are praised and vaunted. Black female artists for instance, who reinforce stereotypes of blacks as hypersexualized, vulgar, using codes such as twerking to exemplify their over hyper-sexualized nature, are praised as empowering or authentic, where as black male artists are praised as being “real” or “gritty” for expressing unjustified violence directed at other blacks. But this is just to mimic the age old racist justifications for slavery although slavery, in name, has been outlawed. According to this justification, blackness represents a blurred distinction between human and animal.

Man distinguishes himself from animality, but this is not the case for the Black Man, who maintains within himself, albeit with a certain degree of ambiguity, animal possibility. A foreign body in our world, he is inhabited under cover—by the animal. To debate Black reason is therefore to return to the collection of debates regarding the rules of how to define the Black Man: how he is recognized, how one identifies the animal spirit that possesses him, - under which conditions the ratio penetrates and governs the animalitas. (Mbembe 2017, 56)

It is not necessarily clear where to find the literature on specifically what is at issue here. Because of this, I think it will be helpful to start with something of an analogy, specifically one from the popular narrative. In the newest Wicked screen adaptation, there is an underlying story line. The protagonist, the ‘wicked’ witch finally comes to accept that she will never be accepted by the broader public and as such, will always stand out as a scapegoat of sorts owing to her dark green skin. Therefore she fully leans into her ‘wicked’ persona.

However, perhaps a detail which could not be included as prominently in Gregory Maguire’s 1995 novel. The amazing actress, Cynthia Erivo, is an African American with especially prominent features, accentuated owing to the excellent applied makeup and superb acting by Erivo. Through both movies, it is obvious that she isn’t green in reality, but African American. We see the story of the witch as a case of othering. As such, especially poignant was the moment when Dorothy, believing the witch can be killed throws a bucket of water on her, an old racist trope about African Americans and bathing.

It is a fortunate accident I suppose, director John M. Chu taking perfect advantage of the fact that the witch in the original dies having had a bucket of water thrown onto her. The witch, fully adopting her role, seemingly for the good of the people of Oz, ‘dies’, but in the fiction, merely goes into hiding. Ultimately Elphaba and Prince Fiyero, turned Straw man, strike out to the desert after her sacrificial death accepting that they will forever be scapegoats should they choose to stay in Oz.

This is the naive view:

It can perhaps be with a bit of irony that one pursues the study of African American literary critiques. At once, these critiques are leveled against a system that is responsible for their own publishing. Frantz Fanon’s, we might naively

say, is one such example. It is perhaps uncouth to look at a book's publishers in an effort to more fully understand the semantic content of that book. Explanations of how the book came to exist are not thought to lend much support in assessing the validity of an author's claims. Unfortunately however, the temptation to do so can be quite overwhelming at times.

Perhaps there are reasons why an understanding of the processes surrounding a book's existence are an important part of the existence of that book, for instance the Western education of the author, the book's distribution, the retail outlets, libraries, and classrooms, that represent the demand for the book.

Naively, I might be led to think that without any of these artifacts of a culture, that a given book would not exist. More important however, are those specific motivations that go into the book's creation. The demands of the editor, positive reviews by reviewers, a public's insistence that such a book needs to be written. Lastly, there is a worry that only certain authors can write a given book, such that if anyone else were to write it, it would not be received by publishers, editors, or the public.

A similar critique here is Frantz Fanon's exploration of the effects of colonialism in the psychology of Africans. Of concern both for Fanon's work as well as Jackson (2020), it can be difficult to disentangle what might be considered a person's culture in isolation from the affects of colonialism. I myself am sceptical that such a project could be successful.

To read a word like Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks*, then, for someone as unsophisticated as myself, can be quite a daunting task. In the foreword, written by Anthony Appiah, it is claimed *Masks* is confronting the psychological affects of racism. This is an important point, given that Fanon himself is trained as a psychologist. However, Fanon begins the introduction using colonial expressions of old world notions of blackness as objects devoid of personhood. These expressions prove to me to be quite difficult obstacles to surmount.

The books target initially then is "black" empowerment which would involve the acquisition of knowledge. The problem with the above however, is that any correlation between knowledge and power is wrong from a Christian world view. Rather one is grounded in power if they have humility. "The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom." Collins mentions the 19th century black feminist scholar Maria Stewart, noting that she urged self-reliance and independence and that her work was suppressed along with many other black feminist scholars of the era. However, we as a society know a lot more about the importance of community and inter-personal relationships, a fact which Stewart herself draws attention to:

This is a common position in what is lauded as "African American Studies". Often times these positions are wrapped in the language of "struggle". While Collins notes that this "struggle" is a struggle for empowerment, it is not particularly clear who the struggle is directed at. She argues that the struggle is global and transcendent, she defines the struggle as one for "survival." But she expands the target in this edition to include recent developments of sexuality and "sexual politics" of black womanhood.

Here, the implication is not on knowledge, knowledge without wisdom is useless and a fool's errand, it does not lead to "empowerment". As noted in the feminist and social epistemology literature, there are many divergent accounts of knowledge and while the discourse may focus on one account of knowledge as being central to empowerment, they are often missing other accounts of the importance of knowledge. Collins mentions the 19th century black feminist scholar Maria Stewart, noting that she urged self-reliance and independence and that her work was suppressed along with many other black feminist scholars of the era. However, we as a society know a

lot more about the importance of community and inter-personal relationships, a fact which Stewart herself draws attention to:

You have souls committed to your charge. . . . It is you that must create in the minds of your little girls and boys a thirst for knowledge, the love of virtue, . . . and the cultivation of a pure heart.

Here, an important development is that Stewart draws a deep connection between knowledge and virtue.

The Virtue of Luck (a reading of luck and ethics from Fragility of Goodness)

What is the relationship between human virtue and environmental variables? In order for a trait to be the virtue of a human being, some would like to say that it has to represent choices, rationality, actions, beliefs. However, often times these depend on environmental variables which we do not control. Most importantly among these are the values that we hold dear to us. Whether or not we recognize the importance of close relationships for instance. However, if the luck question is accurate, even these values depend on factors that are outside of our control. Our fragility, need for loved ones, friendship, etc., can at one time depend on whether or not we've encountered sufficient hardships for instance, but even outside the experience of hardships, friendships, which are also external and an environmental variable at once hold intrinsic importance, although these are external to us. As such "human goodness is nourished, even constituted, by external happenings". [1-2]

Non-Scientific Deliberation

Practical Deliberation

- Not scientific
- appropriate criterion of correct choice is a person of practical wisdom (thoroughly human being)
- therefore vulnerable to ungoverned *tuche* whereas Plato thinks that a good human life, a person exercising practical wisdom is invulnerable to luck

How then are good judgments of value made?

The vulnerability of the Good Human Life

All human excellence requires external resources and necessary conditions.

- External objects to exercise virtues towards
- External objects to receive our virtues

The most important of these require relational virtues.

E.g.,

- Good activities of citizenship
- Political attachment

- Personal love
- Friendship

The Relational Harm of Slavery

Good character requires civic activity, good political surroundings.

A slave however, lacks:

- choice
- *philia*

A person needs to be able to make free and un-coerced choices. A slave is unable to do so since he belongs to someone else who makes choices for him. Owing to his inability to make free and unconstrained choices, a slave is unable to use their capacity for practical reason, choosing objects for their own sake. As such, they cannot share in *philia* which “is based on mutual respect for choice and character” [348].

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